

CFO-ORC FILE # 1997-2
accepted 7-0
med 12-31-97

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X

Species: Purple Finch (*Carpodacus purpureus*)

Date: 25 December 1997 **Number seen:** one **Sex:** unknown **Plumage:** non-ad. male

Locality: Red Rocks Park Trading Post **Elevation:** about 6300'

Nearest town: Morrison **County:** Jefferson

Time observed: about 10AM **Duration of observation:** one minute

Description: While sorting through juncos looking for the eastern Fox Sparrow that had been present at this site for a week, I suddenly realized that I was hearing the call note of Purple Finch. It sounded close, so I searched for the bird in the surrounding vegetation. I quickly located it at the top of the small tree next to me and the bird was mostly facing me. It was a medium-sized finch (thick, conical bill; shortish, notched tail) that was basically brown and white. The head was large with a prominent white superciliary that extended from near the top of the bill (it didn't quite reach the bill) to behind the auriculars; it was narrowest between eye and bill. The chin and throat were unstreaked white. I did not note the presence or absence of an eye ring. The culmen was somewhat curved, not arrow-straight as in Cassin's Finch. I did not see the back well enough to describe other than it appeared brown. The underparts were white with thick, brown streaking that was relatively sharply defined. The undertail coverts were apparently unstreaked, though my view of them was not optimal and I might not have noticed faint or thin streaking; the bird definitely did not have dark, noticeable streaking on the undertail coverts.

I tried to photograph the bird (I had my camera with me), but shortly before I would have gotten it in focus, a Sharp-shinned Hawk scared all the nearby birds away, including the Purple Finch. All (?) other birds eventually returned, but I did not see or hear the Purple Finch again in the subsequent 40 minutes that I was present at the site.

Similar species eliminated: Cassin's Finch (the most similar species) by call note, head pattern, bill shape, and undertail coverts pattern; House Finch by call note, head pattern, and bill size and shape (too large and stout for House Finch); any *Pheucticus* grosbeak by size (subject barely more substantial than nearby juncos) and call note.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): The bird called numerous times (15-20); the call was distinctive, being a very dry, unmusical "pik". This call note is unlike that of Cassin's Finch and is not particularly similar to the call note of any bird with which I am familiar.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing (and -sounding) species? I have seen 10,000+ Purple Finches all over the east. I have heard the call notes of Purple Finches on 100s of occasions. I have seen bazillions of House Finches and 100s of Cassin's Finches. I have lived with House Finches most of my birding career, so am familiar with (I think) all of its vocalizations. I have heard Cassin's Finches the least of the three North American *Carpodacus*, but I know its call note well now, having three summers of field work in the Colorado mountains under my belt. I have seen 100s of female *Pheucticus* grosbeaks.

Light conditions: Bird was somewhat backlit when seen perched, but it was very close, making the somewhat poor lighting of no consequence.

Optical equipment used: Zeiss 7x42

Distance, and how estimated: estimated at 10 feet minimum distance

Other observers who saw the bird with you: none

Other observers who saw the bird independently: none of which I am aware

If photographed, type of equipment and film: not photographed

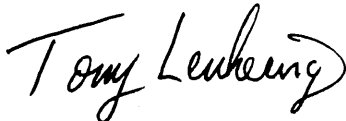
List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: none

This report was written from notes made shortly after observation.

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature: 

Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Piccadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 26 December 1997

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS - SIGHT RECORD FORM

NEW STATE RECORD _____ UNUSUAL RECORD X **Species:** Purple Finch (*Carpodacus purpureus*)**Date:** 1 and 10 January 1998 **Number seen:** one **Sex:** ?? **Plumage:** non-adult male**Locality:** Red Rocks Park Trading Post **Elevation:** about 6300'**Nearest town:** Morrison **County:** Jefferson**Time observed:** 10:15 AM (1st); 12:18-12:22 (10th) **Duration of observation:** brief; 4 mins.

Description: When I first found this bird on 25 December 1997, I didn't get a long look at the bird, but heard it well and saw enough to know that it was a Purple Finch. I took notes immediately after the bird departed and wrote documentation soon thereafter. Upon seeing it on 1 January, I noted that I had gotten a couple aspects of the bird's plumage wrong, so, after seeing it quite well today (leisurely through my scope), I am writing new documentation directly from my field notes taken while I was looking at the bird.

An obvious non-adult male *Carpodacus* finch (big headed, brown and white, with streaking underneath, and a strong head pattern) that was slightly larger than nearby House Finches. The large head had a large bill with a somewhat-curved culmen. There was a prominent white superciliary that extended from just in front of the eye to well behind it. There was a very thin buffy supraloral stripe (visible only through scope) that did not extend to the bill. The throat was pale, but washed strongly with an orangey-yellow color; the throat feathers had barely visible (through scope) dusky centers forming exceedingly vague broken streaks, but these were only visible through the scope; through binoculars, the throat appeared unstreaked. The thick, dark malar stripes were all the more prominent due to the virtual lack of markings on the throat. They were also set off by broad, pale submoustachial stripes that were buffy anteriorly and flared and became white posteriorly.

The underparts were heavily streaked with medium to dark brown; paler, warmer, and blurrier streaks on the chest gradually changing to darker, cooler, more sharply-defined streaks on the flanks. The undertail coverts were unstreaked, though I didn't see those feathers all that well. At least a few uppertail coverts were approximately the same orangey-yellow color of the throat, but I never saw that feather tract well. The tail was comparatively shorter than that of a nearby House Finch, but was much more strongly notched. The brown back was streaked with pale and the wing coverts and secondaries were fringed with bright buff. The plumage had a strong yellowy cast to it.

While many are calling this bird an immature male, I am unsure of the age and sex of it. Pyle (1997) states that "Most HY/SYs in Aug-Apr are not reliably sexed. Some HY/SYs can be reliably sexed male by 1) the presence of a distinctive pinkish or yellowish tinge to the plumage (*known HY/SYs only* [italics mine])...." Since I could not age the bird, I do not feel comfortable in sexing it.

Similar species eliminated: Cassin's Finch (the most similar species) by call note, head pattern, bill shape, and undertail coverts pattern; House Finch by call note, head pattern, and bill size and shape (too large and stout for House Finch); any *Pheucticus* grosbeak by size (subject barely more substantial than nearby House Finches) and call note.

Describe the bird's song and call, if given, including method of delivery (i.e. from perch, in flight, duration): The bird called once upon flying away; the call was distinctive, being a very dry, unmusical "pik". This call note is unlike that of Cassin's Finch and is not particularly similar to the call note of any bird with which I am familiar.

What is your prior experience with this and similarly-appearing (and -sounding) species? I have seen 10,000+ Purple Finches all over the east. I have heard the call notes of Purple Finches on 100s of occasions. I have seen bazillions of House Finches and 100s of Cassin's Finches. I have lived with House Finches most of my birding career, so am familiar with (I think) all of its vocalizations. I have heard Cassin's Finches the least of the three North American *Carpodacus*, but I know its call note well now, having three summers of field work in the Colorado mountains under my belt. I have seen 100s of female *Pheucticus* grosbeaks.

Light conditions: Sky was bright overcast.

Optical equipment used: Zeiss 7x42 and Kowa 30x wide-angle

Distance, and how estimated: estimated at 50 feet minimum distance

Other observers who saw the bird with you: Chris Blakeslee on the 10th

Other observers who saw the bird independently: many

If photographed, type of equipment and film: not photographed

List books, illustrations, recordings, other birders, etc. consulted and how this influenced your identification:

a) at time of observation: none

b) after observation: Pyle, P. 1997. Identification Guide to North American Birds. Slate Creek Press, Bolinas, CA.

I referred to Pyle (1997) only to determine ageing and sexing criteria and the book had no influence on my identification of the species, but did confirm my remembrance of the inadvisableness of sexing brown Purple Finches of which the age is unknown. This report was written from notes made shortly after observation.

Reporting observer: Tony Leukering

Signature: 

Address: Colorado Bird Observatory, 13401 Piccadilly Road, Brighton, CO 80601

Date report was written: 26 December 1997

CFO-RC FILE #: 1997-2
mid 3-98

COLORADO FIELD ORNITHOLOGISTS
SIGHT RECORD FORM
RESULTS: _____

PLEASE PRINT OR TYPE. ATTACH PHOTOGRAPHS AND ADDITIONAL PAGES IF NECESSARY.

SPECIES: Purple Finch Carpodacus purpureus
(COMMON NAME) (SCIENTIFIC NAME)

DATE(S) OF OCCURRENCE: JAN 2 1998

NUMBER OF BIRDS SEEN: ONE SEX: IMMATURE MALE PLUMAGE: IMMATURE molting

EXACT LOCATION: Feeding station at Trading Post in Red Rock Park

COUNTY: Jefferson NEAREST TOWN: MERRISON ELEVATION: 6000

LENGTH OF OBSERVATION: Total 5 mins TIMES(S) OF OBSERVATION: between 08:30 & 09:30 at intervals

OTHER OBSERVERS WHO INDEPENDENTLY SAW THE BIRD(S):

Dick Schottler - Golden Co.

LIGHT CONDITIONS [QUALITY; DIRECTION RELATIVE TO BIRD(S); POSITION]:

PARTLY Cloudy, calm Temps low 20's, sun at observers back or off left shoulder

OPTICAL EQUIPMENT USED: Ziess 10x40

DISTANCE FROM BIRD (ESTIMATED UNLESS OTHERWISE NOTED): 25-50 Feet

WAS THE BIRD PHOTOGRAPHED: NO IF SO, HAVE YOU SUBMITTED PHOTOS? _____

WHO TOOK THE PHOTOGRAPHS? _____

DESCRIBE THE GENERAL AND SPECIFIC HABITAT IN WHICH THE BIRD(S) OCCURRED:

Seen in and around feed station with nearby Gambel's quail oak and occasional choke cherry with grass/weed undergrowth

DESCRIBE THE BIRD'S BEHAVIOR (FLYING; FEEDING; HABITS; BEHAVIORS USED IN IDENTIFYING THE SPECIES OR IN SUPPORTING THE IDENTIFICATION):

The Bird was seen roaming with a flock of House finches occasionally feeding at feeders or perching atop Gambel's oak. The flock would disappear for awhile and then reappear near the feeder area.

DESCRIBE THE BIRD IN DETAIL. THIS IS THE MOST IMPORTANT PART OF THIS REPORT. INCLUDE OVERALL SIZE AND SHAPE, AND HOW YOU PLACED THE BIRD IN THE GENERAL GROUP THAT YOU DID. GIVE COMPLETE DETAILS OF PLUMAGE, INCLUDING HEAD, THROAT, UNDERSIDES, NAPE, BACK, WINGS, AND TAIL. GIVE PARTICULAR EMPHASIS TO MARKS YOU USED TO IDENTIFY THE BIRD(S). DESCRIBE OTHER DETAILS, SUCH AS COLOR AND SHAPE OF BILL, LEGS, EYE, ETC. THAT WERE IMPORTANT IN MAKING THE IDENTIFICATION. (FILL OUT THIS PORTION EVEN IF PHOTOGRAPHS ARE SUBMITTED; YOU MAY ATTACH ADDITIONAL SHEETS, DRAWINGS, FIELD SKETCHES, OR COPY OF FIELD NOTES):

This was a small Brown Bird that was slightly more robust than nearly House Finches.

* Bill - Dark finch type Bill appearing more massive than House Finch yet not longer

* Head - Brown streaked head with broad white/pale supercilium
Noticeable Brown Auricular patch

Throat - Pinkish white color with out streaking.

Body - Breast and belly off white color finely streaked with brown giving way to heavier, longer streaks as you approached the flanks
Nape Back, wings were Brown streaked.

Rump - Bright clear yellow/orange.

Tail - Brown

* undertail coverts - unstreaked white

Legs - Brown

DISCUSS SIMILAR SPECIES AND HOW YOU ELIMINATED THEM:

H. Finch - Brown streaking is present on undertail coverts, lack a prominent ^{light} supercilium

Cassin's Finch - more conical banded Bill, streak undertail coverts. Cassin tend to hold crown feather erect some of the time.

WHAT IS YOUR PRIOR EXPERIENCE WITH THIS AND SIMILARLY APPEARING SPECIES?

Common species, seen reg at feeders growing up

LIST BOOKS, GUIDES, RECORDINGS, OR OTHER SOURCES CONSULTED AND HOW THIS INFLUENCED YOUR IDENTIFICATION (DURING AND AFTER OBSERVATION):

Birds of N.A. NAT. GEO

THIS REPORT WAS MADE FROM NOTES MADE DURING _____ OR AFTER _____ OBSERVATION, OR LATER FROM MEMORY X.

DATE OF WRITTEN REPORT: 3-11-98

REPORTING OBSERVER: Ric Olson SIGNATURE: ROR
9450 N Heather Dr CASTLE ROCK CO 80104

SEND REPORT TO: MARK JANOS, 10 SEDUM COURT, PUEBLO, CO 81001